

Four Paths to Victory

The economy-primary design, consolidated to **four scored races**. Military is no longer a path — it's a shared **tool** whose every use feeds the attacker's own engine, and the warlord fantasy now lives inside **Domain-by-force**. Each path competes for the same bottlenecks: **land, labor, time**.

How you win

Achieve the **HIGH** goal of one path **and** the **MEDIUM** goal of a **different** path. Four players filling two path-slots each $\approx$ every path contested twice — no peaceful parallel races.

THE SIX AXES — THE TENSIONS EACH ECONOMY POSITIONS ALONG

Tall ◀vs▶ **Wide** density / sprawl

Depth ◀vs▶ **Breadth** long chains / many basics

Tempo ◀vs▶ **Scaling** rush / compound

Specialize ◀vs▶ **Diversify** monopoly / self-sufficient

Hoard ◀vs▶ **Flow** stockpile / velocity

Extract ◀vs▶ **Sustain** burst / regenerative

THE FOUR PATHS

Economic

THE MERCHANT

HIGH

Hold **1,000,000 gold** continuously.

Held 30 min · announced realm-wide when the timer starts

MEDIUM

Bank **500,000 gold** (once).

- ⚙️ Specialize on one good, win on **trade velocity** — then switch to hoard discipline. Not-spending is the whole tension: the hoard fights every other path's need to build.



⚔️ COUNTERED BY **The Embezzler** — skims gold from the announced hoard.

⌘ WAR AS TOOL Raids **pillage gold** → loot funds your own 1M.

Religious

THE FAITHFUL

HIGH

Convert **75%** of your people + the faith of **2 other territories**.

Sustained ~10 min · announced at 80%

MEDIUM

50% conversion + **1 other territory**.

- ⚙️ Shrines & preachers drive **conversion rate**. Because it's a *percentage*, it's easier with a small dense flock — which naturally anti-synergizes with Domain's giant population.



- ⚔️ COUNTERED BY **The Inquisitor** — discredits & re-converts, dropping your %.

- ✖️ WAR AS TOOL **Seize a territory by force**, then convert it.

- ⚖️ ANTI-SYNERGY A big population makes your % target far harder.

Science

THE SCHOLAR

HIGH

Complete the **science tech tree** + **build 2 wonders**.

Wonders are visible & sabotageable · announced as each nears done

MEDIUM

1 wonder + **75%** of the tech tree.

- ⚙️ A lean, flexible economy that **sprints the era ladder**, funnelling every surplus into research and construction. Fast but interaction-light unless its wonders can be attacked.



- ✂ COUNTERED BY **The Saboteur** — wrecks wonder progress or steals a tech.
- ✕ WAR AS TOOL Loot resources to fund wonders; raid to sabotage a rival's.
- ⚙ ANTI-SYNERGY Wonders demand spending — the enemy of the gold hoard.

Domain

THE SOVEREIGN • WARLORD HOME

HIGH

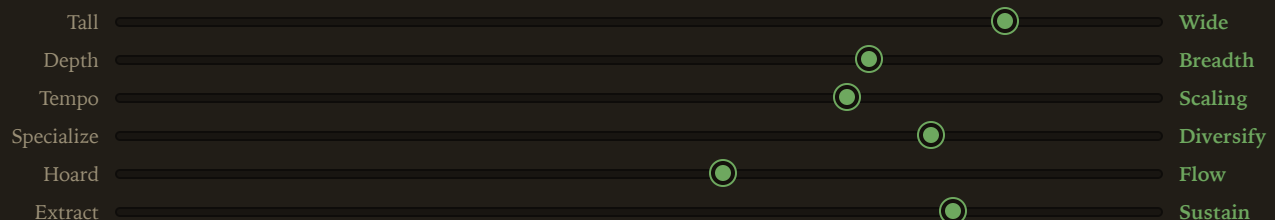
5,000 population + hold 5 territories, each with a medium keep.

Sustained ~10 min · announced at 80% · territories won by growth OR conquest

MEDIUM

2,500 population + 2 territories.

- ⚙ Wide expansion; **food variety** → **happiness** → **census**. Territories can be grown peacefully *or taken by force* — this is where the aggressive player wins, no separate military crown needed.



- ✂ COUNTERED BY **The Agitator** — incites your peasants to emigrate.
- ✕ WAR AS TOOL **Conquest annexes** territory & population directly.
- ⚙ ANTI-SYNERGY Sprawl is raidable; a huge pop makes Religion-secondary hard.

THE SHARED LAWS — WHAT KEEPS IT BALANCED

Dual goal

High in one path + medium in another. No single-stat cheese; every path contested.

Everything is announced

Cross ~80% of any high goal and the whole realm is told — opening the counterplay window.

Sustained-hold windows

Every high goal must be *held* for a set time, not snapped shut — so spies & raids have something to bite.

One clock

A single match timer decides the winner at the buzzer; its length is your master dial (short favors tempo, long favors scaling).

Diminishing returns

Over-investing one track has a falling ceiling, keeping hybrids attractive.

War feeds the attacker

Every act of war advances your own path (loot / annex / sabotage) — no spite-only grieving.

Reserve path for the first expansion → Splendor / Beauty: the “beautiful castle” fantasy, a genuinely different scoring shape (adjacency & symmetry), countered by an Arsonist.